

One-punch rise

“I’m not invincible. I’m beatable.” Those aren’t words you expect from a **newly crowned** two-division UFC champion. But Ilia Topuria’s self-awareness might just be what makes him unstoppable.

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Holding a belt in the UFC is a mark of greatness. But to claim gold in two different weight classes — and hint there’s room for more — is a rare blend of dominance and drive. Ilia Topuria did just that. At UFC 317, the Spaniard added the vacant lightweight championship to his resume with a ruthless first-round knockout of former champion Charles Oliveira. With the victory, Topuria dethroned Islam Makhachev and now sits atop the men’s pound-for-pound rankings.

Topuria, already a featherweight titleholder, stepped up in weight but lost none of his venom. Known for his crisp boxing, explosive power, and

rock-solid takedown defence, he brought all those weapons to the Octagon — and barely needed a round to unleash them.

The lead-up had been electric. Topuria (**below, left**), undefeated and exuding swagger, was seen as the next big thing. But Oliveira, a former lightweight king, was no stepping stone. With wins over Dustin Gaethje, Justin Poirier and Michael Chandler, he had faced — and beaten — the division’s best.

Early on, Oliveira tried to dictate terms with body kicks and pressure,

backing Topuria toward the fence. A brief scramble saw Topuria secure side control before Oliveira threatened with a leg lock. Calm and calculated, Topuria escaped and brought the fight back to the feet — a pivotal moment. Seconds later, the finish came with chilling precision. A probing jab drew Oliveira’s guard just wide enough for Topuria to sneak in a thudding right hand. One punch. Lights out. New champion.

Now 17-0, Topuria isn’t just perfect on paper — he’s perfect in purpose.

But behind the bravado lies a fighter grounded in self-awareness.

“I am not invincible,” Topuria said after the fight. “Quite the contrary. I feel that I’m beatable, and that’s why I work so hard... The work is so well done that I feel that there’s no doubt left.” In the co-main event, Alexandre Pantoja retained his flyweight crown with a clinical performance against Kai Kara-France. Dominating the grappling exchanges, Pantoja controlled much of the bout on the mat before locking in a rear-naked choke in the third round.

It marked Pantoja’s fourth successful title defence, further cementing his status as one of the flyweight division’s all-time elite.



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